stopped eating meat on Fridays – the holiest day of the Muslim week – and he hoped that others, though 'wolfish' in their habits, would follow his lead.

'[H]ail to the lofty perception which keeps sovereignty shoulder to shoulder with saintship . . .!' Abul Fazl cries out. Badauni was less impressed. In fact, Akbar's changing diet was among the many pieces of evidence that Badauni uses to allege the emperor's apostasy from Islam, laying much of the blame for it on his Hindu wives, whom Akbar would join in their rituals,[30] and under whose influence he had repudiated beef, onions and garlic, along with 'men who wore beards'.

For all that Akbar was glad to experiment with Hindu – indeed any – ritual and philosophy, he does not seem to have been rejecting Islam, certainly not in the absolute terms that Badauni alleges. Thus, for example, the first big miracle of 1578 was that of a hermit reciting the azaan.

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Eighteen-odd months earlier, in mid-1576, Man Singh had led the Mughal army against Rana Pratap of Mewar at the famous battle of Haldighati.

Much is often made of the great rivalry between the Rana of Mewar and the Emperor of Hindustan, both equally stubborn in their will for victory. 'Single-handed . . . did he withstand the combined efforts of the empire,' writes Colonel James Tod of Rana Pratap's long and romantic resistance,
'. . . flying from rock to rock, feeding his family from the fruits of his native hills, and rearing the nursling hero Amra [his son], amidst savage beasts and scarce less savage men, a fit heir to his prowess and revenge.'[31]

It is true that the rana was determined not to submit to the Mughal, and ruthless in his pursuit of independence. Until Chittorgarh was regained, Rana Pratap declared, Mewar would forsake every luxury: its nobility would eat from plates of leaf, not silver and gold; its men would not shave; the great *naqqara* drums would follow the troops, not lead them. Peasants, he said, would no longer cultivate their fields, so no aspiring conqueror would gain as much as a grain of wheat from his land. 'The silence of the desert prevailed in the plains,' writes Tod, 'grass had usurped the place of the waving corn; the highways were choked with the thorny babul, and beasts of prey made their abode in the habitations of his subjects.' In addition to such 'patriotic severity', Rana Pratap sent out regular plundering